PRACTICE PAGE · PAST SIMPLE VS. PAST PROGRESSIVE

when or while?

Name _____ Class _____ Date _____

WHILE + LONG ACTION

While I **was walking** home, I met Noa.

While needs something that **lasts**.

WHEN + SHORT ACTION

I was walking home **when** it **started** to rain.

When also works with a long action.

TWO LONG ACTIONS

While I **was cooking**, my sister **was studying**.

Both progressive; *while* is best.

Watch out: *"While I've done my homework…"* is wrong. *I've done* is the Present Perfect (finished, connected to now). In a story about the past, use **I was doing**.

1 Circle when, while or both

1 I was having a shower **(when / while / both)** the phone rang.

2 **(When / While / Both)** we were eating dinner, the lights went out.

3 **(When / While / Both)** the film ended, everybody clapped.

4 She cut her finger **(when / while / both)** she was cooking.

5 **(When / While / Both)** I heard the news, I called my best friend.

6 I was doing my homework **(when / while / both)** my parents were watching TV. *Which is better?*

2 Past Simple or Past Progressive?

1 While Dana _____ *(wait)* for the bus, it _____ *(start)* to rain.

2 I _____ *(cut)* my finger when I _____ *(make)* a salad.

3 While my brother _____ *(play)* video games, my sister _____ *(read)* a book.

4 When I _____ *(see)* the spider, I _____ *(scream)* and _____ *(run)* away.

5 My phone _____ *(ring)* while I _____ *(take)* the test. How embarrassing!

3 Right or wrong? · tick ✓ or cross ✗, then correct the wrong ones

1 While I've done my homework, my parents watched the news. ✓ ✗

_____

2 I was walking home while it started to rain. ✓ ✗

_____

3 When I was walking home, I met my cousin. ✓ ✗

_____

4 While we was playing outside, my mum called us. ✓ ✗

_____

5 We were watching TV when the electricity went out. ✓ ✗

_____

4 Your turn · three true sentences about last week

a **when** + a short action _____

b **while** + a long action _____

c two things at the same time _____

TEACHER ONLY · ANSWER KEY

when or while?

1 Circle when, while or both

#	Answer	Why
1	**when**	"The phone rang" is a short action. *While* can't introduce a moment.
2	**both**	"We were eating" is long, so *when* and *while* both work.
3	**when**	The film ending happens in a moment.
4	**both**	"She was cooking" is long.
5	**when**	Hearing the news is a moment, and the two actions happen one after the other.
6	**both · while is better**	Two long actions at the same time. *When* is correct but less natural.

2 Past Simple or Past Progressive?

#	Answer	Why
1	**was waiting**, **started**	*while* + long action; the rain starting interrupts
2	**cut**, **was making**	Cutting happened in the middle of making. *Cut* is irregular: cut–cut–cut
3	**was playing**, **was reading**	Two long actions at the same time
4	**saw**, **screamed**, **ran**	All Past Simple: a sequence, one action after another. *When* + Past Simple in both clauses = "first this, then that"
5	**rang**, **was taking**	The ring interrupts the test

Item 4 is the trap: students who think "when always means interruption" write *was screaming*. Use it to show that *when* + Past Simple + Past Simple means one action after another.

3 Right or wrong?

#		Correction	Why
1	✗	While I **was doing** my homework, my parents watched / were watching the news.	*I've done* is the Present Perfect, not a story tense
2	✗	I was walking home **when** it started to rain.	*While* can't introduce a short action
3	✓	Correct.	*When* can introduce a long action
4	✗	While we **were** playing outside, my mum called us.	*we were*, not *we was*
5	✓	Correct.	Long action + short interruption

4 Your turn: what to check

- **a** The *when* clause holds a short action in the Past Simple, e.g. *I was sleeping **when** my alarm went off.*
- **b** The *while* clause holds a long action in the Past Progressive, e.g. ***While** I was waiting for the bus, I saw my teacher.*
- **c** Both verbs are in the Past Progressive, ideally with *while*, e.g. *While I was cooking, my brother was setting the table.*

Common slips to look for: *was* + base form ("I was go"), *while* + a short action, and the Present Perfect used for a story ("While I've…").